



Vitamin D deficiency is a national crisis in India, not just an athlete problem. Twenty minutes of mid-morning sun on bare arms helps, but most athletes training indoors or in the early morning need supplementation. Get your 25-hydroxy Vitamin D tested and correct it if needed.

Omega-3 fatty acids in the EPA and DHA forms are largely absent from plant diets. Flax seeds, chia seeds, and walnuts provide ALA, but conversion to EPA and DHA in the body is poor. Vegan athletes should consider an algae-based Omega-3 supplement. Vegetarians can use one too, or include eggs.

Calcium, zinc, and iodine round out the list. Ragi, til, paneer, curd, soaked almonds, pumpkin seeds, and iodised salt should all feature regularly in your weekly rotation.

Fuelling around training

This is where I see talent get wasted.

Two to three hours before training, give your body a mix of complex carbohydrates and moderate protein. Think poha with peanuts and a glass of milk or soya milk, upma with sprouts, or a banana with peanut butter on multigrain

toast. Within 30 to 60 minutes after training, hit a quick recovery combination of carbohydrates and protein. A banana with whey or pea protein in water, a curd-rice bowl, or a smoothie with soaked dates, oats, and protein powder all work beautifully.

Hydration in Indian conditions deserves respect. Most athletes train in temperatures that demand 600 to 900 ml of fluid per hour of activity, plus electrolytes. Coconut water, lemonade with a pinch of pink salt, or a properly formulated sports drink for sessions lasting more than an hour can all do the job.

A simple one-day template

Early morning: Soaked almonds, walnuts, and a glass of warm water with lemon.

Breakfast: Vegetable poha with peanuts, two boiled eggs or a bowl of curd, and a fruit.

Mid-morning: Smoothie with banana, dates, peanut butter, oats, and a scoop of plant or whey protein.

Lunch: Two rotis, dal, rajma or chole, a vegetable, salad with lemon, and a bowl of curd.

Pre-training: A banana and black coffee or green tea.

Changing times: Roughly four out of ten Indians grow up vegetarian, and a rising number of young athletes are now experimenting with veganism for ethical, environmental, or gut-health reasons. GETTYIMAGES

Post-training: A recovery shake plus a fruit.

Dinner: Paneer or tofu bhurji, jowar roti, sautéed greens, and a small bowl of curd.

Before bed: Warm milk or soya milk with a pinch of turmeric.

The final word

A plant-based diet can absolutely take you to the top. I have seen it happen in cricket dressing rooms, athletics camps, and on the badminton court. But it demands planning, testing, and respect for science. You cannot wing this.

Eat with intention. Train with discipline. Test your blood every six months. And remember: food is your first sponsor. Choose it like your career depends on it, because it does.